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STARTUPS



How founders are ditching VC norms and finding capital on their own terms at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025



TechCrunch Events — 7:30 AM PDT · July 31, 2025

At [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#), happening October 27-29 at Moscone West in San Francisco, a candid conversation is coming to the [Builder Stage](#) — one that unpacks what startup funding looks like beyond the venture capital chamber.



Funding routes that don't start in the Valley

Founders today have more capital paths than ever. But how do you navigate them — and know which one actually supports your growth? In this session, hear from Erik Allebest, the CEO and co-founder of [Chess.com](#); Gale Wilkinson, the founder and managing partner at [VITALIZE](#); and Kay Makishi, vice president at [Lupoff/Stevens Family Office](#). Each brings a different perspective on how to raise money without giving up your vision or your cap table.

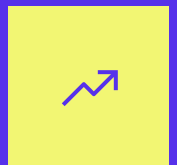
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- Spotify raises subscription prices

Whether you're bootstrapping, tapping family offices, or building through angel networks, this discussion breaks down what's working now, what to avoid, and how to choose the approach that fits your goals.

- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

Meet the speakers carving out new funding lanes

[Erik Allebest](#) turned a college passion into Chess.com, now the leading platform for players and learners with over 165 million users. Built without chasing venture capital, it's a bootstrapped success story in a league of its own.

[Gale Wilkinson](#) has made 50 personal angel investments and led more than \$80 million in early-stage funding across 150 startups. She's a WorkTech expert, a champion for diversity in venture, and a go-to voice for founders who want capital that shares their values.

[Kay Makishi](#) brings a cross-border lens as a key investor at a New York-based family office. With experience spanning U.S. and Japanese markets, she offers rare insight into how high-net-worth individuals and families back startups for impact, not just returns.

Skip the status quo and fund smarter

There's more than one way to get to your next round. Don't miss this [session](#) that shows how founders are funding differently — and winning. [Grab your pass](#) to TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 today to save up to \$675 in ticket savings, and be in the room with 10,000+ startup and VC leaders.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital, Elad Gil — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$600+ before prices rise.

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IMAGE CREDITS: SLAVA BLAZER FOR TECHCRUNCH

STARTUPS



Elad Gil — one of tech's sharpest minds — on early bets, breakout growth, and what's coming next at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events — 7:00 AM PDT · August 7, 2025

Elad Gil isn't just ahead of the curve — he practically lives there. Before most of the world had even asked ChatGPT its first question, Gil was writing early checks into companies like Perplexity, Character.AI, and Harvey. And that's just a slice of the story. His track record includes seed or Series A investments in more than 30 unicorns and involvement with some of the most iconic names in tech — Stripe, Airbnb, Coinbase, Instacart, Notion, Figma, Flexport, GitLab, and many more.

This October, Gil takes the [Disrupt Stage](#) at [TechCrunch Disrupt 2025](#) in San Francisco for a fireside chat that promises to cover a lot of ground.

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He'll cover everything from his approach to spotting breakout potential early to how he's thinking about the next big wave of innovation. Whether you're building in AI, crypto, health tech, or enterprise SaaS, this conversation is a rare opportunity to hear how one of Silicon Valley's most prolific investors sees the road ahead.

[Register early](#) to pocket real ticket savings and join valuable conversations with startup heavyweights like Gil.



Why this one matters

There are VCs, and then there's [Elad Gil](#). With operating experience at Google and Twitter, multiple founder wins, and a portfolio that reads like a who's who of tech success stories, he brings a rare mix of operator empathy and investor clarity. His bestselling book "High Growth Handbook" is required reading for startup leaders scaling fast, and his ability to decode markets before they shift is second to none.

In this one-on-one, we'll go deep on early-stage investing, new frontier technologies, and what it really takes to build a category-defining company. From the inside out.

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Don't miss the valuable takeaways — only at Disrupt 2025

Join 10,000+ startup and VC leaders [October 27–29 at Moscone West in San Francisco](#). From headline-making sessions to hands-on networking, Disrupt is where the future of tech gets built — and this fireside with Elad Gil is just one of many reasons to be in the room. [Register here](#) to snag your seat for this exclusive discussion.

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FUNDRAISING

How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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stakes moments in any founder's journey: raising your first round.

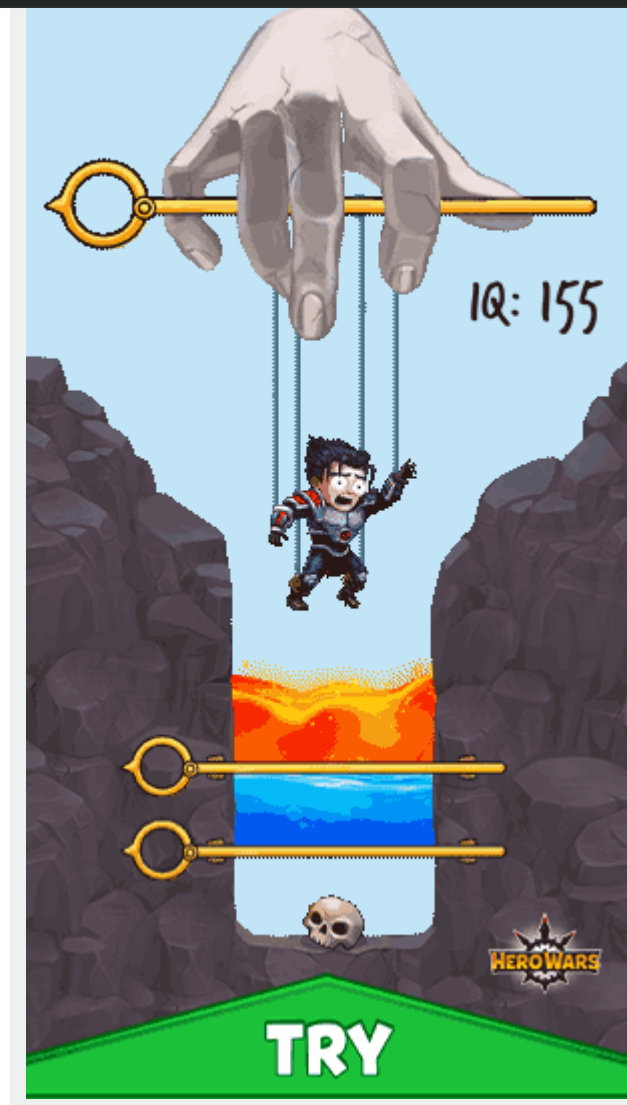
[Register now to save up to \\$675 on your ticket](#) and join this conversation — plus 200+ more sessions across five industry stages, roundtables, and breakouts. Prices go up tonight at 11:59 p.m. PT.



From pitch to partnership: The real roadmap to seed funding

This dynamic panel brings together three seasoned investors — Maria Palma (Freestyle Capital), Gabby Cazeau (Harlem Capital), and Marlon Nichols (MaC Venture Capital) — to unpack the realities of early-stage fundraising. From shaping a compelling pitch to choosing the right capital partners, they'll share honest, actionable insights to help founders translate interest into investment.

[Maria Palma](#), general partner at [Freestyle Capital](#), brings deep operating and investing experience, with past roles at Kindred Capital, RRE Ventures, and leadership positions at high-growth startups like Eyeview. She's backed companies such as Fung Money, Lightning Labs, and Payman, and holds an MBA from Harvard.



Latest in Fundraising

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TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



Elad Gil — one of tech's sharpest minds — on early bets, breakout growth, and what's coming next at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

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[Gabby Cazeau](#) is a partner at [Harlem Capital](#), investing in pre-seed and seed startups across enterprise software and applied AI. She holds an MBA from Yale and a BS in chemical engineering. Gabby has been featured in Business Insider, CNBC, and Crain's 40 Under 40, and serves on the VC Council of Startup:NYC.

[Marlon Nichols](#), co-founder and managing general partner of [MaC Venture Capital](#), leads one of North America's top seed-stage firms with over \$600 million AUM (assets under management). A multiple-time honoree on Business Insider's Seed 100 and PitchBook's list of top Black VCs, Marlon has helped scale industry-shaping companies like Blavity, Thrive Market, and MongoDB.

TECHCRUNCH DISRUPT 2025



Final call: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket savings end tonight

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What to expect on the Builders Stage

This isn't your typical venture panel. Expect sharp insights on how to cut through the noise, structure your raise, and build relationships that last beyond a term sheet. Whether you're gearing up for your first round or advising a founder who is, this is the session you don't want to miss.

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Catch Palma, Cazeau, Nichols, and [250+ tech heavyweights](#) across the six industry-specific stages, as well as in breakouts and roundtables, live at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025, at Moscone West in San Francisco. [Register now](#) and lock in up to \$675 in ticket savings before today ends!

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VENTURE



Final call: TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 ticket savings end tonight

TechCrunch Events — 6:00 AM PDT · August 6, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

KIMBERLY WHITE / GETTY IMAGES

TechCrunch Disrupt 2025 marks 20 years of shaping the startup world — and tonight's your last chance to save up to \$675 on your ticket.

From October 27–29, Disrupt returns to Moscone West in San Francisco. Join 10,000+ tech innovators, founders, VCs, and ecosystem builders for three days of high-impact programming, networking, and startup energy.

But first: your savings. You have until 11:59 p.m. PT tonight to save up to \$675. Once the clock strikes midnight, prices jump. [Register now.](#)

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Why you won't want to miss this 20th-anniversary Disrupt

TechCrunch Disrupt has been the launchpad for breakthroughs and next-generation deals for 20 years. It's not just another tech conference — it's where game-changing innovations are born, powerful connections are made, and ideas turn into action.

One session, one meeting, one moment — that's all it takes to change your trajectory. Disrupt is where startups break out, investors find the next big thing, and industry leaders stay ahead of the curve.

Featured Disrupt 2025 speakers

- Roelof Botha, [Sequoia Capital](#)
- Jeff Cardenas, [Apptronik](#)
- David George, [Andreessen Horowitz](#)
- Alex Kendall, [Wayve](#)
- Eunice Kim, [Netflix](#)
- Tekedra Mawakana, [Waymo](#)
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- Raquel Urtasun, [Waabi](#)
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- Sangeen Zeb, [GV \(Google Ventures\)](#)
- ...and many more. New speakers are announced weekly. [Check the speaker page](#) often.



IMAGE CREDITS:HAJE KAMPS / TECHCRUNCH

Here's what's happening at Disrupt

Four Industry stages + the Disrupt Stage

Dive into the tools, trends, and tactics founders need to grow, scale, and lead in a competitive market. Stay tuned as new sessions are frequently added to [the agenda](#).



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- **Builders Stage:** Growth playbooks and founder realities
- **AI Stage:** Two days covering agents, creativity, defense, EV, hardware, and regulation
- **Space Stage:** Where tech meets the cosmos
- **Going Public Stage:** Candid lessons from companies that made it

Interactive sessions

Join candid conversations with startup pros in small-group roundtables and breakout sessions. Ask real questions, get unfiltered answers, and gain in-depth insights not covered on the big stages.



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IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

Startup Battlefield 200

Watch the top 20 TechCrunch–picked startups pitch live on the Disrupt Stage for a \$100,000 equity-free prize — with real-time VC feedback.

Explore what's next

Step into the Expo Hall and meet the startups creating tomorrow's tech. Founders: Want in? [Exhibit your startup](#) and get in front of investors, media, and future customers, before tables run out.

Make the right connections

Disrupt isn't about meeting *more* people — it's about meeting the *right* ones. Braindate helps you find those key conversations that move your goals forward, whether in a 1:1 or small-group format.

Additional benefits for investors and founders

The Deal Flow Café is where investors and founders connect over coffee to talk deals, raise rounds, and spark momentum.

In addition to access to the Deal Flow Café, Investor and Founder Pass holders unlock exclusive

benefits designed to make an impact:

- **Investors:** Enjoy a curated tour of the Expo Hall with formal introductions to startups that align with your investment focus. Plus, your reserved seat at the exclusive **StrictlyVC** session on Day 2 awaits.
- **Founders:** Get face time with investors actively scouting for their next big bet, whether you're raising now or building for what's next.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH

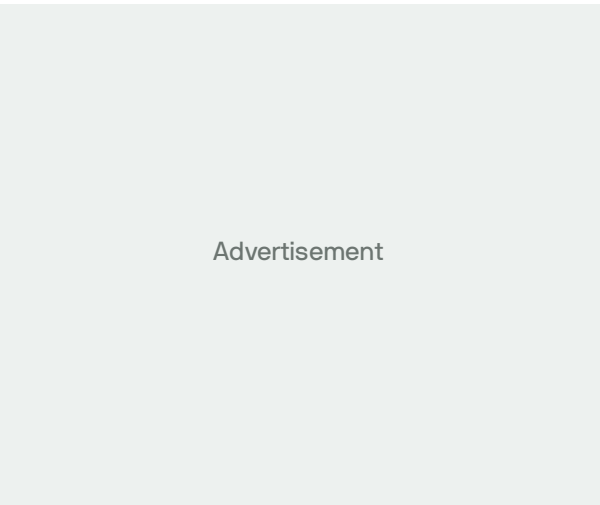
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You've got until **11:59 p.m. PT tonight** to save up to \$675 on your Disrupt 2025 ticket. Don't miss one of the most anticipated tech conferences of the year. [Register now](#) and lock in your savings before prices go up after tonight.

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